

Autonomy in agrarian studies, politics, and movements: An inter-paradigm debate

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This article is part of a future Special Issue: Autonomy in Agrarian Studies, Politics, and Movements.

Abstract

Autonomy has been a term often used in agrarian studies to express the ability of individuals or collective subjects to escape the rule of capital or the control of the state. Academic interventions on autonomy in different fields and disciplines discuss how global capitalism operates and what kind of subjects, spaces, and practices can resist it and build alternatives to it. However, a closer look at the literature reveals contending notions of autonomy. This special issue therefore aims to stimulate theoretical debates on autonomy. This introduction provides an overview of the general problematic and major theoretical debates around which the discussion on autonomy has been taking place. This problematic is not specific to rural social subjects but involves the discussion within the Left about the need and possibility for radical social change. This article explores how ideas about autonomy are used by radical agrarian movements and critical agrarian studies scholars. It also presents the key issues covered by and the arguments of the different contributors to this special issue.

KEYWORDS

autonomy, critical agrarian studies, political theory, social movements

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1 | INTRODUCTION

Autonomy has been a word that has been rolling off the tongue of leftist academics and activists and has made its way into numerous academic articles and books. It is often used to express the ability of individuals or collective subjects to escape in one way or another the rule of capital or the control of the state. Within peasant movements, especially but not exclusively in Latin America, the concept has referred to the ability of peasants to mount collective responses to the dominant actors in the market or within the state, and remain independent from political parties or politicians. The call and search for autonomy has also been important within women's movements with respect to the left, within indigenous movements through their struggle for self-determination vis-à-vis the nation-state, and within the anti-capitalist left, especially groups influenced by anarchism. In past decades, academic interventions on autonomy in different fields and disciplines have been fundamentally about assessing how global capitalism operates and what kind of subjects, spaces, and practices can resist it and build alternatives to it. Autonomy has been theorized from Marxist, Anarchist, Foucauldian and Feminist perspectives. It is paradoxical however that autonomy has emerged as a key political concept and strategy during an era in which the logic of capital has increased its grip on all spheres of society and when the radical left has been in retreat in most parts of the world.

Within critical agrarian studies, the backdrop to the discussion on autonomy has been the growing transnationalization of national food regimes, the rise of agribusiness, increased market concentration of downstream and upstream activities in agriculture, the privatization of natural resources, and the exponential growth of extractive industries that are displacing rural populations and polluting their ecosystems. The corollary to this image is often the shrinking market space for small-scale producers, the increased reliance on labour migration for rural households, and the general precariousness of rural livelihoods. In many regions of the Global South, these processes further undermine the cultural survival of indigenous or afro-descendent peoples, who have demanded autonomy long before the implementation of neoliberalism. To this picture one must add the recent rise of authoritarian agrarian populism that simply accelerates these processes and represses attempts to resist them. Consequently, the challenge for critical agrarian scholars interested in autonomy has been centred on characterizing the nature of peasant households and indigenous communities and their place within capitalist development. One of the foci of this is to analyse the ability of these rural subjects to reproduce themselves partly through non-capitalist relations and to defend their cultural distinctiveness through their struggles for autonomy. But it has also been about analysing the formation of alliances with dominant or dominated classes or with majoritarian ethnic groups when they belong to excluded minorities. This can help to determine whether they can resist the dominant trends and build an alternative to it.

The persistence or disappearance of non-capitalist or non-commodified forms of access and control of land and natural resources, as well as the persistence or disappearance of non-capitalist or non-commodified relations of production and exchange, are the crux of the discussion. On the one side, we find authors who adopt the category of the peasant and understand peasant producers to have an inherent quality that other producers do not have, whereas others emphasize that peasants are constantly participating in a contradictory process of class formation. On the opposite end, authors who reject this category consider that the great majority of poor agricultural producers are now completely subsumed by the capitalist logic, because their reproduction is conditioned or determined by broader capitalist relationships (e.g. grounded on particular social relations of property, prices of land and labour power, and so on). Concurrently determining what is the function and goal of these forms and relationships can lead to the adoption or the rejection of the category, for either analytical or political reasons (Bernstein, 2006; Bernstein, 2014; Jansen, 2015; McMichael, 2006; McMichael, 2015; van der Ploeg, 2014). To some extent, these contrasting views on the class nature and behaviour of the rural poor form the basis of distinctive paradigms in the understanding of the contemporary agrarian world, which do not often

engage in debate or dialogue with each other. One of the key objectives of this special issue is to bring them together to begin this inter-paradigm debate.¹

In these discussions the notion of autonomy has been presented as central to the peasant condition (van der Ploeg, 2008), whereas others have argued that autonomy is context-specific and fundamentally politically constituted, that is, autonomy is possible if movements create autonomous rural communities and territorialize their struggles (Vergara-Camus, 2014, chap. 3). However, a closer look at the literature shows the lack of proper definition of the concept of autonomy despite it being used extensively. This could be because often the claims or demand for autonomy combine different dimensions. What is said to be one of the foundations of autonomy, for instance collective control and use of natural resources, may derive from cultural norms and practices of particular ethno-cultural groups. Thus, the demand for autonomy of certain agrarian movements that expresses itself as a struggle to occupy a political space to influence agrarian policies and/or to gain margins of manoeuvre vis-à-vis the market can be theoretically distinguished from claims for autonomy emphasizing the right to self-determination of ethnic groups within a larger state constellation. But the fact that they are interwoven in reality makes it difficult to effectively separate them analytically.

The lack of definition of the concept of autonomy is also due to the fact that scholars have argued that different social subjects seek autonomy from different oppressive structures. Böhm et al. (2010) argue that social groups seek autonomy from the market, from the state, and from development. Broadly speaking, we could identify three theoretical strands in the use of the concept of autonomy that correspond to three different targets, which sometime are combined. The first strand draws inspiration from several traditions, notably Anarchism and *Operaismo* (see next section) and builds its conception of autonomy on the notion of 'self-valorization'. It emphasizes the necessity of creating autonomous spaces, driven by the value, creativity and innovation of labourers themselves. A second strand emphasizes autonomy from the state, with the Zapatista movement in Chiapas as an example. John Holloway who argues in favour of breaking with the myth of the revolution by ceasing control of the state and changing society from there, is the most well-known theorist of this strand (Holloway, 2002). This involves first a negative movement that rejects the system of exploitation and domination, destroys existing structures of power, and build alternative horizontal and participatory ones. The third strand rejects the mainstream conception of development and encompassed approaches that fall within the alternative development or post-development paradigms. Important proponents of these approaches are thinkers like Escobar (2006), Max-Neff (1991), Rahman (1993), Esteva and Prakash (1999), Mies and Bennholdt-Thomsen (2000), who propose a sort of 'defensive localization' by focusing on grassroots empowerment, the preservation of local knowledge, local histories, and community cultures and practices that are threatened by the expansion of capitalist relations. As we will see in the latter part of this introduction, these strands are replicated in the agrarian debate about autonomy through discussion about whether subaltern rural subjects can avoid the market or not, whether they can bypass, confront or influence the state, or whether their agricultural practices can be the basis of an alternative to capitalist agriculture.

If under the era of neoliberal globalization peasant and indigenous autonomy deserves the special attention of critical agrarian scholars interested in alternatives to neoliberalism, the recent developments and challenges stemming from the Covid-19 pandemic have made it even more urgent. In many countries of the global North,

¹This is neither the place nor is there room in this introduction for a thorough description of the two paradigms within critical agrarian studies. In order to keep the discussion as open-ended as possible, we have chosen to use mainly the term 'peasants' and only occasionally 'petty commodity producers'. We recognise that the use of each term is associated with a different theoretical and analytical tradition. The authors themselves have different views on the scope of these terms: either using both terms to refer to similar rural subjects or preferring a conceptual distinction between peasant and petty commodity producer. In the context of this article we use the term peasant to refer to the poorest agricultural producers in the Global South for whom subsistence-oriented production plays a crucial role in their social reproduction but who also may produce for the market. We also use the term peasant when referring to social movements who identify themselves as such. At some points, we mention both terms when explicitly writing about market-oriented commodity production or about a series of different types of producers.

Covid-19 revealed the fragility and lack of flexibility of the global food regime (e.g. price fluctuations of food items, infections among workers in meat packing plants, and massive infections of animals on mink farms in the Netherlands). A return to a nationally-focused food regime and the rise of shorter commodity circuits, ingredients in some autonomous projects, seem less unrealistic than a few years ago. In the global South, the coronavirus pandemic and lockdowns forced millions of informal wagedworkers to move back to their rural communities because they lost their jobs and there were no more livelihood prospects for them in cities. It has shown how the recourse to the rural community is part and parcel of the survival strategy of large sectors of the working poor; family, kinship and social ties becomes crucial when everything else crumbles. In this context, politicians, and state officials, unwilling or unable to provide welfare for their most marginalized population, assumed that their 'communities of origin' would provide support for them. A serious scrutiny of past and current experiences of autonomy in the face of a crisis of social reproduction will contribute to our understanding of the challenges and contradictions that subaltern rural subjects face when they seek to confront their marginalization and mobilize their collective political power.

This special issue will unravel the theoretical, political and normative role of the notion of autonomy in different discussions and organizational strategies, thereby contributing to the ongoing theoretical discussion about the politics of agrarian change. The contributors to the issue will explore the theoretical challenges and limitations of the adoption of the notion of autonomy by scholars and social movements. To do this, the special issue will examine the struggles and demands for autonomy by farmers, workers, peasants, indigenous peoples or social movements, through an examination of social institutions, the household division of labour, relations of production and social reproduction, as well as collective strategies of rural movements to define their class and ethnic identity and defend and promote their interests. This special issue will explore the question of autonomy within agrarian studies and movements through a combination of theoretical interventions and case studies. Following the tradition of the *Journal of Agrarian Change*, the different uses of and perspectives on autonomy will be critically discussed from an agrarian political economy approach and placed within contexts of contradictory and complex class and ethnic relationships.

The nature of the topic and the foundational theories feeding into the discussions around autonomy requires that we follow an open interdisciplinary approach drawing from different philosophical, political, and sociological theories. The debate on autonomy that has been going on in the social sciences for the past half-century is relevant as it will help to come to grips with divergent political positions and strategies. It will also clarify a much-used notion that has been scarcely systematically theorized in agrarian studies. As the following brief review will show, autonomy is a polemic term for the Left because it addresses fundamental questions about social change, subjectivities, and agency in the process of building alternatives to capitalism or neoliberalism.

In the following pages, we will provide readers with an overview of the general problematic and the theoretical debates around which the discussion on autonomy has been taking place. This problematic is not specific to rural social subjects but involves the discussion within the Left about the need and possibility for radical social change. With this general discussion in the background, we will follow with a section that shows how these ideas made their way into radical agrarian movements and critical agrarian studies and how the concept of autonomy is used by rural activists and academics. The paper will conclude with a presentation of the key issues covered in the special issue and the central focus and argument of the different contributors.

2 | CRITICAL POLITICAL THEORY, RADICAL SOCIAL CHANGE AND AUTONOMY

Autonomy as a political concept embraced by agrarian movements and some agrarian studies scholars bears marks of longstanding discussions within the radical Left about revolutionary change, capitalism, the individual, the collective, and the state. These discussions, it is important to highlight, did not take place first within working classes circles in Europe and later in the non-Western world. Just as today, ideas were travelling back and forth and were

not restricted to narrowly defined working classes but included from the beginning rural subaltern classes.² In the early days of Marxism, autonomy referred firstly to the political independence of the proletariat, more specifically to the possibility and the capacity of workers to organize an independent movement that would struggle for social change and socialist revolution from a class perspective. The competing Anarchist position understood autonomy in the libertarian sense through which the individual as a revolutionary subject rejected hierarchy and authority exercised either through the market or the state and associated him or herself freely with other individuals. This was fiercely criticized by Marx and Engels among others,³ but there are within Marx's own thought and writings, beginning with the 1844 Economic and Philosophical Manuscripts going all the way through to his writings on the Paris Commune of 1871, numerous ideas that share more than simple similarities with Anarchism. Anarcho-syndicalism produced another more collective conception of autonomy, corresponding with the notion of self-management in the late nineteenth and early twentieth century. Herein, 'the concept of autonomy is linked to the practices and the experiences of self-determination undertaken in the workers' councils' (Modonesi, 2014, p. 88). Councilism, self-management, self-government, and self-valorization have been key ideas in such workerist perspectives across the world. The Flores Magón brothers even developed an agrarian version of it that fitted very well with the grievances and forms of organization of peasant and indigenous communities in Mexico in the eve of the Mexican revolution of 1910–1917. This *problématique* is however not a monopoly of Anarchists. It has been at the forefront of the most important discussions between activists and theorists during revolutionary moments anywhere in the world. Lenin's and Trotsky's writings on the role of soviets and the party during the early days of the Russian revolution, Rosa Luxemburg's interventions in favour of spontaneity of the labouring classes in Germany, and Antonio Gramsci's journalistic coverage and enthusiastic support of workers councils in Turin around the same period are early examples of this. Even if Marxism-Leninism imposed itself across the world of communism, especially in the Third World, and put party discipline and vanguardism on a pedestal, there were echoes of this too in revolutionary Cuba of the 1960s, Chile of the early 1970s and Nicaragua in the 1980s. In debates in Africa, discussions of autonomy appeared in the politics of delinking as proposed by critical thinkers as Fanon, Amin, and Cabral, amongst others (Ajl, 2018), and in auto-centred, self-reliant development proposals by Third Worldist agronomists and economists (Ajl, 2019).

In Europe, the concept of autonomy re-emerged in the 1970s and 1980s around the *operaismo* (workerism) of Mario Tronti (Tronti, 2019) and Antonio Negri (Negri, 1984) in Italy, and in France through the work of the intellectuals participating in the journal *Socialisme ou Barbarie*, especially Cornelius Castoriadis (1987, 1997). Many of these interventions promoted the idea that workers or marginalized groups were capable of (and better off with) self-government and that they should reject the vanguardism of bureaucratic and corrupt central organizations like national unions or political parties. Both groups were also drawing inspiration from wildcat strikes and grassroots factory struggles of the late 1970s that did not remain within the boundaries set by their national leaderships. There are however important differences between the two groups. The Italian group was clearly grounded in Marxist theory, whereas the French one rapidly rejected Marxism, proudly moved to a post-Marxist position to adopt an eclectic mix of psychoanalysis and radical liberal democratic theory.

Castoriadis' conception of autonomy for instance is centred on the individual and is defined by the ability to take decisions self-reflexively and participate in the democratic process that constitute society. Autonomy is opposed to

²In the late nineteenth century, workers and peasant groups in Latin America (Argentina, Uruguay, Bolivia, Chile, Mexico) were drawing on concepts and debates from Europe but also having their own discussions about mutualism, cooperation and anarcho-syndicalism. There are also countless stories of Indian workers and intellectuals migrating to the different parts of the world (USA, Canada, Brazil, Mexico, Turkey, the Caribbean, etc), getting involved in workers and peasant struggles there and coming back to fight to end British rule.

³Engels (1978) wrote, for example: 'We have seen, besides, that the material conditions of production and circulation inevitably develop with large-scale industry and large-scale agriculture, and increasingly tend to enlarge the scope of this authority. Hence it is absurd to speak of the principle of authority as being absolutely evil, and of the principle of autonomy as being absolutely good. Authority and autonomy are relative things whose spheres vary with the various phases of the development of society. If the autonomists confined themselves to saying that the social organisation of the future would restrict authority solely to the limits within which the conditions of production render it inevitable, we could understand each other; but they are blind to all facts that make the thing necessary, and they passionately fight the world.'

the concept of *heteronomy*, which for Castoriadis represents a state in which individuals conform to the norm and the culture of consumerist society, and have no independently free will (Castoriadis, 1996). Consequently, he sees the process of emergence of a collective will in fairly Liberal terms in which an individual develops the ability of transcending her or his individual interest by reflecting on the common good. In contrast, for *operaismo* autonomy was still something that began in the workplace around relations of production and spilt over into the sphere of circulation and into social life in general under capitalism. The search for autonomy was like an inherent impulse of labour to rid itself of the yoke of capital. Labour's struggles to free itself and ultimately to abolish work is what constantly transforms capitalism, not the logic and the needs of capital accumulation.

Antonio Negri built his argument about autonomy around a very abstract, peculiar, and at times quasi-esoteric reading of Marx' *Grundrisse*. For him, the *Grundrisse* showed how Marx did not see labour as the object of capital, but that the relationship between them was one between subjects and even more a conflict of subjectivities, a relation of power. For Negri, the *Grundrisse* reminds us that because of the very functioning of capitalism, labourers have power. When they fight over their wage and to reduce the portion of surplus value that capital extracts from their work; when they demand that capital respond to their needs; when they begin to see the power of their labour and the power of redrawing it or abolishing their subordination to capital altogether; and when they begin to use their labour power for other purposes than to serve capital, labourers are in the field of 'self-valorization'. This can lead to 're-appropriation' (of the means of production) and communism. In later work Negri (1999) continued to defend autonomy, moved towards the issue of revolutionary subjectivities and radical democracy (Negri, 1999), but leaving in the background issues pertaining to political economy. His use of political economy however has always been much more via abstract theoretical discussion and broad generalizations than through the use of concrete case studies and empirical evidence drawn from other sources. In *Empire* (2000), the most emblematic and influential text of the re-emergence of the concept of autonomy, Hardt and Negri (2000) mix Marx with Foucault, Deleuze, Guattari, and Castells among many, to paint a picture of an all-powerful empire with no clear centre that functions through a combination of primitive accumulation, discipline, and biopolitics. For them, *Empire* is an empty machine that lives off all labour: wage labour, unpaid labour, and immaterial labour. However, *Empire* finds the 'multitude' and the 'militant' within it, capable of developing a counter-power and reconstructing the commons by fighting for self-revalorization and re-appropriation. Though fascinating, very little of their highly comprehensive book builds on the analysis of concrete movements. The processes leading the rise of resistance movements and the challenges and contradictions of their politics are left unexplored. The reader is left with the choice of having to accept the possibility of autonomy in a leap of faith or reject it as a simple utopia.

Working from the complete corpus of Marx's work, Tronti makes the argument that Marx's study of capitalism cannot be divided in his 'political' writings and his 'economic' ones. Revolution against capitalism and the understanding of capitalism are intimately intertwined. For him the key is to return to seeing capitalism in class terms from its very origin and understand it as constituted and reproduced by class antagonism and conflict. In some sense, Tronti reverts Marx's early idea of the process of class formation that he captured with the distinction between 'class in itself' (when it exists objectively in the process of production) and 'class for itself' (when it gains consciousness of its distinctiveness, interests, and collective power). Tronti summarizes his approach in this sentence: 'First the proletariat, then labour-power; first the workers as a class politically, then the economic category as an articulation of production; first the antagonistic class, then the function of capital (Tronti, 2019, 182)'. For Tronti, the bourgeoisie could not have emerged and developed capitalism if the proletariat had not existed already and thus capital cannot be accumulated if labour power is not provided by workers. Analytically, this means that the 'political' process of the development of class consciousness and power that negate exploitation has to take central stage, instead of the different ways in which capital controls labour. For Tronti, however, Lenin more than Marx provided the key to unravelling the revolutionary potential of the proletariat. For autonomous projects more broadly, this means that the central question becomes which are the collective experiences, identities, struggles, and forms of organization that form a class *in opposition to another*.

In the 1950s and 1960s, leftist activists in other regions of the world were also challenging the bureaucratic nature of traditional unions and Communist parties. Harry Cleaver for instance highlights that in the United States similar ideas and political tendencies within the labour movement and the left emerged but added a local flavour. Already in the early 1950s, C.L.R James and Raya Dunayevskaya called for the recognition of workers' self-activity and for the autonomy of Black workers within the union movement, as well as the autonomy of Black struggles from the parties of the left (Cleaver, 2000). Cleaver himself has been one of the proponents of autonomy within the current Marxist literature.

Beyond the very important differences among all the presented intellectuals, what united the post-1968 theorists who deployed the term autonomy is their strong belief in spontaneous subjectivity, independent agency, and self-government of labouring classes (or the excluded and marginalized for post-Marxists). They also emphasize the possibility (and necessity) of social change beginning in everyday life through the construction of spaces (in the workplace and the neighbourhood) that lie outside the hegemony of capital and the state. Recent philosophical debates on autonomy have challenged the notion of individual autonomy that authors like Castoriadis defend. Mackenzie and Stoljar (2000) have criticized from a feminist perspective the notion of the autonomous individual, 'as ideally self-sufficient, as operating in a vacuum unaffected by social relationships or as an abstract reasoner stripped of distorting influences such as emotions' (Stoljar, 2015). They have sought to dissociate autonomy from its most individualistic conceptions while defending it against other feminist critiques. Silvia Federici (2004), following the *operaismo* tradition, has offered an alternative feminist postcolonial perspective on the transition to capitalism in which the autonomy of labouring classes plays a central role. She highlights the countless struggles of working-class women in Europe and the Americas who challenged the new laws that reorganized the household and imposed the patriarchy of the wage. She also shows how in certain instances in Caribbean plantation societies enslaved Black women and White working-class women bypassed racist laws and collaborated to develop food markets to increase their independence from men (2004, pp. 112–113). Their struggles against these laws were struggles against the rule of the state and capital to recover the autonomy that they had prior to the process of primitive accumulation.

The term autonomy re-emerged once more with the global repercussion of the Zapatista uprising in 1994 and the rise of the 'anti-globalization' movement in aftermath of the Battle of Seattle triggered by the protests against the meeting of the WTO in 1999. It was also a point of reference in the discussion in Argentina in the 1990s around the unemployed *Piquetero* movement, the occupied factories, and later the popular assemblies that sprung after the financial crisis of 2001. The idea of autonomy was also central in the popular and indigenous mobilizations in Bolivia and Ecuador around the same time but were articulated more toward indigenous claims for self-government. In Latin America, Raul Zibechi is without a doubt the intellectual who can be more directly connected to the autonomist tradition. He interprets these movements as rejection of the alienated nature of labour within capitalism, and as attempts of labourers (workers and peasants) to free themselves from capital and property and to build alternative communities (Zibechi, 2010). Latin America indeed witnessed an unprecedented wave of social mobilization in the 1990s. But in the West, if *Operaismo* and *Socialism ou Barbarie* had emerged in the context of the crisis of Fordism and the welfare state that were accompanied with a rise in strikes, industrial actions of all kinds, and the rise of 'new social movements', this time organized movements had suffered close to two decades of neoliberalism and were weak. Autonomy was now often de-centred from class and attributed to excluded and marginalized groups.

The discussion between Anarchists and Marxists about autonomy vis-à-vis the state and capital, and the way of organizing the exercise of autonomy has not gone away. It reverberates through contemporary debates. For example, David Harvey (2017) attempted to combine the activism of some contemporary autonomist groups with a Marxist analysis of capital circulation and accumulation. However, a key area of disagreement seems to be on how to mobilize political power; for Harvey 'the state cannot be neglected as a potential site for radicalization' (p. 249). Within Anarchism the idea of a personalistic commitment to individual autonomy has been criticized and set against a view on autonomy as a collectivist commitment to social freedom (Bookchin, 1995). Bookchin (1995) criticizes individual lifestyle Anarchism and opposes it to social Anarchism. Autonomy as figuring in narratives of alternative

food networks and food sovereignty echoes these debates. On the one hand, the withdrawal from mainstream markets and their replacement by alternative food networks may be driven by individual consumer choice for alternative values, the self-oriented individual pursuing a lifestyle not dictated by capital or the state. On the other hand, it may be seen as a form of communalism (still based on private property though, rather than Bakunin's collective Anarchism), forming confederations of like-minded people and social movements to undertake political action and interact with like-minded institutional actors (or groups within institutional actors). On the Anarchist side of the spectrum a strong opposition to the state is being maintained whereby the state is seen as simply an instrument of Empire. With his communalism, Bookchin seeks 'freedom' rather than 'autonomy'. For him, autonomy is a problematic notion, for it is too much based on the sovereign and the self-sufficient individual.

Claims for more autonomy are often easily made but the term is saturated with contradictions. Böhm et al. (2010, p. 24) argue that 'autonomy cannot claim to have an essential "ground," a space which is completely "beyond" capital, state or development'. Autonomy is never complete and it can never be reached but only 'understood as a permanent and ongoing struggle' (p.24). Böhm et al. therefore speak of the impossibility of autonomy, especially if it is understood as autarky or complete isolation, as an 'outside the system'.

Jansen et al. (2022) in this issue argue that this idea of being outside the system is indeed present in some claims of the repeasantization perspective. But this first meaning of autonomy alternates with a second meaning: one that does not consider autonomy as 'outside the system' but as operating within the system and against it, trying to transform or transcend it. As Harvey (2017, p. 238) argues: 'It is theoretically and relationally defined solely by that from which it seeks to be autonomous'. Autonomy and claims for autonomy can only be understood in their relational context. Or as Böhm et al. (2010, p. 24) phrase it: 'despite the discourse of self-determination and self-organization at the heart of autonomous movements, autonomy cannot be seen to be detached from accumulation processes of capital, nor from liberal democracy, nor development. Rather, it is intertwined with these modes of social life, which autonomous social movements seek autonomy from'. This implies that autonomy cannot be accepted at face value (nor simply rejected because of the autarky connotation it sometimes evokes). Autonomous projects of social movements cannot be analysed in isolation. Communities or movements who claim to be autonomous must be understood within and assessed in respect to the larger capitalist context.

3 | AUTONOMY IN AGRARIAN STUDIES AND AGRARIAN POLITICS

The three claims for autonomy mentioned at the beginning of this introduction—autonomy from the market, from the state, and from development—have made their way into discussions about the future of marginalized rural producers and the construction of alternatives to the neoliberal globalization of agriculture across the world. Even though these claims for autonomy are fundamentally intertwined, for analytical purposes we could say that the discussion around each of them brings a different aspect of agrarian life to the forefront. The discussion around autonomy from the market focuses on production and reproduction. The discussion around autonomy from the state focuses on rural politics. The discussion around autonomy from capitalist agrarian development focuses on farming, technology, and ecology.

3.1 | Autonomy vis-à-vis the market

In their attempts to carve out a space for themselves within the process of capitalist development that is often controlled by large capitalist landlords and farmers, as well as multinational corporations and oligopolies, peasants and petty commodity producers have adopted a diversity of collective strategies and tactics. The first three quarters of the twentieth century are replete with peasant revolts, rebellions and revolutions through which peasants sought to resist or revert the expansion of capitalist relations in the countryside. Battles around the privatization of common

land, the commodification of land, the replacement of paternalistic mechanisms of exploitation and domination by capitalist ones, and the generalization of rural wage labour were central to this period. In many regions of the global South, the threat of a red peasant revolution led to the adoption of agrarian modernization policies (land reform, state intervention and market regulation, green revolution technology and extension services). These simultaneously incorporated peasants into commodity production and protected them from a fully capitalist market, while integrating them into the state corporatist apparatus. Redistributive land reform under the 'land to the tiller' banner provided former plantation workers and tenants of large landholdings with the possibility to start co-operatives to end labour exploitation. State intervention was demanded by agrarian movements in order to obtain autonomy from landed elites.

In regions where these policies were more extensive, as in Latin America, the initial adoption of neoliberal policies in the early 1980s was accompanied with the rise of another wave of peasant movements. This time peasants and petty commodity producers were demanding the maintenance of some protective measures (trade barriers, credits, subsidies, etc.) so they could find a space within the increasingly liberalized agricultural market. In many places, these demands were also accompanied by a search for greater control by peasant and petty commodity producers over specific commodity chains through the creation of cooperatives, networks, and associations and the renegotiation of their relationship with the state and political parties. The term autonomy was often the umbrella under which all these demands fitted, autonomy from the market inspiring the former struggles whereas autonomy from the state, to be further discussed below, was added to the latter demand. The question is whether the demand for autonomy from landed elites and peasant producers' organizations have not, with hindsight, simply lead to deeper incorporation into the capitalist economy.

The deepening of neoliberal restructuring of agriculture and food regimes has increased the simple reproduction squeeze on peasant producers and exploitation of rural workers, but many peasant producers and their organizations have continued to look for strategies to adapt to the expansion and deepening of capitalist relations, and the rise of agribusiness and food empires. New strategies towards the market were part of these responses and can be classified into three types: market avoidance, market integration, and market creation (Vergara-Camus, 2018). These strategies are not mutually exclusive and are combined and intertwined in complex and contradictory ways. These strategies are also not necessarily anti-capitalist or even anti-market, as different peasant actors or movements may have different understandings of markets. Strategies of market avoidance are those that imply a conscious decision of retreating from market relations into subsistence production by concentrating efforts on food crops for self-consumption such as rice, maize, beans, potatoes, yam, cassava, etc. (Vergara-Camus, 2014), replacing agricultural inputs that must be bought by those produced 'for free' by nature and humans (what Douwe van der Ploeg, 2010, calls self-provisioning and co-production), thereby tapping into collective socio-cultural narratives of solidarity, reciprocity, redistribution without monetary exchange, and 'commoning' resources. These strategies seek autonomy from the market.

Strategies of market integration are those that imply a deeper involvement with the market, either as seller of agricultural products, as wage worker in agriculture or other industries, or as member of a larger producers' organization that will allow peasant and petty commodity producers to yield better negotiating power vis-à-vis market intermediaries. Those that have sufficient and adequate access to land and natural resources can do the former as a household by switching from food crops to cash crops (e.g. coffee, cacao, and oil palm) or cattle. The option of selling their labour power in exchange for a wage is something that peasant households tend to do periodically but cannot be considered a collective response. The option of joining forces to benefit from economies of scale (at the level of production or simply economic leverage in terms of purchasing power for inputs or for setting the price of a given commodity) continue to be at the heart of countless experiences of producers' associations and cooperatives. It is difficult however to see these strategies of market integration as strategies seeking autonomy from the market. On the contrary, they tend to further expose rural subjects to the vagaries of market fluctuations, especially the recurrent cycles of booms and busts that have historically characterized agricultural commodities. But for governments and for small-scale family producers, this strategy is often undertaken in the name of pragmatism.

Finally, the creation of a new market for their products has recently become an important coping strategy for a minority of organized peasant producers since the 1980s. These new markets take the form of fairtrade network, organic production, local farmers markets, alternative labelling, and certification schemes, etc. Many of these initiatives have sought to build 'nested markets' (van der Ploeg & Schneider, 2022, this issue) that are promoted and protected by the state or local communities to provide an alternative to the neoliberal market. These nested markets are said to operate under different principles than neoliberal free market because often they guarantee a just price for producers, link producers and consumers in more ethical ways, and support local development or short local circuits. Theoretically one of the inspirations of the discussion around the creation of 'different' or 'alternative' markets is Karl Polanyi's substantive approach, which in contrast to Marx's does not cast the market purely in exploitative terms. Polanyi () emphasizes the normative, cultural, and institutional foundations of market relations and provides political economists with different sets of categories, such as reciprocity, redistribution and householding, which suggest the possibility of consciously organizing markets differently. However, a great deal of discussion has been triggered by the market-friendly approach adopted in particular by the fairtrade movement, its problematic certification mechanisms, its mainstreaming into (or co-optation by) the global food industry (Fridell, 2015; Nikol & Jansen, 2021; Reynolds et al., 2007) and its lack of consideration for labour relations within peasant agriculture (Cramer et al., 2017).

As the strategies that seek autonomy from the market have an enormous importance in the ability (or not) of peasants to maintain their livelihood, it is crucial to critically assess the extent to which this is possible and the contexts in which it is. An important question is whether these strategies really provide peasants with autonomy or if they simply are forms of self-exploitation that are functional to capital? For academics, it is equally crucial to discern, compare and contrast the different theoretical understandings of the market, and the class nature of market relations, that are mobilized by the scholars who study these processes. One of the goals of this special issue will be to aim to carry out this task and foster some sort of inter-paradigm debate.

3.2 | Autonomy from the state: Outside, within or through the state

In agrarian studies, James Scott (1976, 1998, 2009, 2012) is a key author commonly associated with the concept of autonomy. To a great extent his prolific career has been dedicated to shedding light on the countless historical experiences of peasant communities resisting the power of the state. Scott has remained constant in his negative view of the state and romantic view of the peasant community. He began with the state as claimant in *Moral Economy of the Peasant* (Scott, 1976), where the state is an entity that extracts a portion of the peasant revenue in the form of taxes. He followed with the state as a rationalizing entity populated by technocratic experts imposing irrational modernist plans on peasant populations in *Seeing like a State* (1998). He culminated with the state as an entity whose reach peasant populations actively seek to escape because of this same appetite for exploitation and control in *The Art of Not Being Governed* (Scott, 2009). On the opposite end, Scott has consistently conceived peasant communities as seeking autonomy from the state to protect their forms of land allocation, rights to the territory, cultural customs and languages, and forms of taking decisions. Although he has always recognized the existence of social inequality and hierarchy within communities, he has nonetheless highlighted that a 'moral economy' maintains exploitation in check by tying the poor and the more well-off around a social contract. Because of its importance and notoriety, Scott's view on the state and peasant communities weighed heavily in the perception of sceptics of the concept of autonomy. Critics of Scott could easily argue that contemporary experiences have shown that peasant communities are not necessarily equalitarian or that peasant movements are not necessarily anti-state or progressive. They can be the social basis for reactionary and right-wing movements. But they can in certain context acquire progressive characteristics and even give raise to anti-capitalist or anti-neoliberal projects. The challenge for critical agrarian scholars is to determine what explains this or that outcome and avoid an a priori judgement on state power. The question is under what circumstance do calls for autonomy depend on or develop an anti-state perspective.

Any study assessing the claims of peasant autonomy from the state would have to venture in a complex critical analysis of the power of peasant movements and their strategies towards state actors and other sectors of their civil society to see which sector of the peasantry they have benefited in last instance. Peasants and petty commodity producers have been key social subjects of radical politics in many countries of the developing world. But 2007 marked the moment in which the majority of the world's population was no longer rural. Considering the complexity of the rural areas of the global South, peasants are probably the majority in only a few less developed countries and there are many countries in which they are actually not even the majority of the rural population. It posed the question of the power that peasant movements can mobilize on their own, but also and more importantly of the kind of peasant demands and proposals that can coincide with those of other subaltern groups of society. How can peasant movements convince other groups to join forces with them? Broadly speaking, four different paths have been followed: to either build alternatives to neoliberalism outside of the state; to pressure the state to implement certain alternative policies; to occupy the state (or parts of it) to establish spaces of self-government to attempt to carry out an anti-neoliberal project; or to build transnational networks to build a common view and coordinate campaigns that eventually will have an impact on state policies.

The Zapatista movement in Chiapas is the most well-known peasant movement that has taken the first path, although there are other cases where peasant movements consciously decide to retreat to isolated areas to avoid the state or the market (Scott, 2009). Many are arguing that the recent Kurdish autonomous region of Rojava shares many of the Zapatista characteristics. The second path of pressuring the state is taken by most peasant movements across the global South but is rarely cast in terms of peasant autonomy because it follows conventional forms of peasant subordination to the state. The policies that may result from these pressures can however reinforce the strategies of peasant movements mentioned above but often according to the terms dictated by state officials. The third path of occupying the state is taken by peasant movements that are strong enough to yield some political influence or have links to political parties. For instance, indigenous movements in several countries of Latin America were able to negotiate forms of self-government over part of the national territory or the control of state programmes. Peasant and indigenous movements in Latin America took further steps along this path in the 2000s by supporting left-wing governments. In Bolivia and Ecuador, peasant and indigenous movements played a key role, first in bringing down neoliberal governments, then in electing left-of-centre nationalist government, and finally inserting pro-peasant principles (like Food Sovereignty, the social function of land, or communitarian forms of production and exchange) into the Constitution of these two countries. However, the policies of these governments continued to promote agribusiness, only funnelling comparatively very few financial resources to small-scale producers (e.g. Córdoba & Jansen, 2014, for Bolivia). In almost all the cases, the needs of rural workers were ignored (Vergara-Camus & Kay, 2017a, 2017b). The question thus remains: what was the place of autonomy in the strategy of peasant movements once allied governments took control of the state? (Bretón et al., 2022, address this question in this issue) In Latin America, the demand for autonomy that remained during this period was the one that was linked to indigenous autonomy (or self-determination) within the nation-state. The objective here was to partly challenge the sovereignty of the state in certain territories, building a kind of 'nested sovereignty', but indigenous movements had all kinds of difficulties in balancing out the jurisdictions and the power of their territorial units with those of the national state (see Guimarães & Wanderley, 2022, in this issue). The fourth path is what the numerous transnational agrarian movements have followed (Borras et al., 2008). Among them, *La Via Campesina* has been one of the most active transnational peasant movements. Its global campaign for agrarian reform contributed to putting redistributive agrarian reform back on the international agenda. Its idea of food sovereignty, which challenges the current corporate-driven global food system, has established itself as a competing paradigm and is generating heated discussions on the Left. As it is a coalition of national movements, many conceptions of the state and strategies towards it coexist within the organization. They use transnational organizing as a boomerang effect on national politics. Nationally, the member movements combine the strategies that make up the different paths that we have mentioned above, but they all take a clear position that they seek to remain autonomous from the state and political parties in order to be able to represent the interests of their members. However, not many studies have analysed

food sovereignty directly through the lens of peasant autonomy. Few studies have explored the role of the state in food sovereignty (McKay et al., 2014; Vergara-Camus & Kay, 2017a), but further studies are required.

3.3 | Autonomy from capitalist agrarian development

Scholars who speak of autonomy from capitalist agrarian development bring together debates on autonomy from the market and autonomy from the state within a broader critique of modernity and its understanding of development. They question the dominant views on agrarian development, that see 'traditional or peasant agriculture' as backward, inefficient, and an impediment to improving the living conditions of the rural population and the economy of developing countries more broadly. They thus reject the idea that the only way to modernize agriculture is to replace peasant knowledge and farming techniques by the most advanced technological development in mainstream agronomy. A basic notion seems to be that peasant agriculture is fundamentally different from capitalist farming. Although most critics of capitalist agrarian development do not reject the fact that modern and peasant technologies are combined in complex ways—and indeed the need for this to happen—many argue that several farming practices that peasants rely on can make them autonomous from capital-driven development and contribute to the environmental sustainability of their region (Barkin & Lemus, 2014). The possibility and desirability of rejecting external chemical inputs is a recurrent theme encouraged by agroecological perspectives. So is the resilience of peasant farming systems that are constructed with locally available resources, adapted to ecosystem dynamics, and built on historically developed local knowledge of nature (Altieri & Toledo, 2011; Barkin & Barón, 2005). Another example of a radical proposal for autonomy is the Zero Budget Natural Farming groups in India (Münster, 2016). Jan Douwe van der Ploeg (2008; 2010) is arguably the agrarian scholar that has developed the most comprehensive theoretical framework to grasp and explain such peasant autonomy. He argues that peasant-driven development differs from dominant development trajectories, implying that alternatives for modernization towards industrial agriculture is possible. Building on a Chayanovian approach, which he adapts to the new context of food empires that exercise their power more by controlling than by owning and producing, van der Ploeg argues that the new peasantries of today maintain a distinctive peasant way of farming. Peasant farming builds autonomy whereas capitalist farming and entrepreneurial farming go together with high levels of dependency. In order to characterize peasant farming, he has coined new terms such as self-provisioning, actively constructed distantiation, and co-production (Douwe van der Ploeg, 2010). The first term refers to the action of tapping into assets, goods, and labour that are accessible to the family farmer on their own farm. The second concept refers to decisions and practices of avoiding the globalized corporate-controlled market for inputs or outputs. The third concept refers to the act of producing agroecologically with nature instead of against it. Van der Ploeg seems to apply a very narrow definition of capitalism in agriculture in which only forms of production based on wage labour can be seen as capitalist. Tilzey (2017) argues that such a narrow definition excludes the commodification of subsistence from being necessarily related to capitalist relations in agriculture. Jansen et al. (this issue) observe that van der Ploeg reserves the notion of autonomy ambiguously and a-symmetrically for a particular type of farmer only, which obscures the differentiated and variegated nature of farmer strategies with the nebulous term 'peasant'. It is up for debate if the autonomy perspective, as developed by van der Ploeg and other recent literature (e.g. Strube, 2019), does not overextend the category of the peasantry to family farmers in developed countries by pointing to the existence of what he considers to be numerous non-commodified spaces in the North. Another issue is whether this conception of autonomy starts analytically from farmer as individuals within the farm gates rather than from social and class relationships, despite all the descriptions of cooperation among farmers.

4 | OVERVIEW OF THE CONTRIBUTIONS TO THIS SPECIAL ISSUE

This special issue will show vibrant debates about the notion of autonomy in contemporary agrarian studies. It will provide the reader of the Journal of Agrarian Change with a selection of case studies that will critically analyse and

assess different experiences of autonomy (peasant, indigenous, women, and guerrilla) by focusing on the different spheres from which autonomy is sought (market, state, development, patriarchy) and the type of collective action adopted by the different groups (economic, political, ethnic/nationalist). The issue will include contributions covering Latin America, the Middle East, and South-East Asia. Some contributions will draw on several case studies to make theoretical interventions (van der Ploeg and Schneider; Jansen et al.) or analytical conclusions applicable to a specific geographic region (Bretón et al.). Yet other contributions will make specific arguments about a single case study (Bolivia, Cambodia, Colombia, Rojava), whilst one contribution will explore how a recent technological development (the Big Data revolution and the rise of surveillance agriculture) is changing the very necessary conditions that make it possible to even think about farmer's autonomy (Stone, 2022).

4.1 | Capitalism in the countryside and in agricultural production

The first discussion of autonomy revolves around the type of agency that emerges around the demand and search for autonomy and the conditions that make autonomy possible. Here the characterization of contemporary capitalism in the countryside, the nature of small-scale farming, and the class position and consciousness of subaltern agricultural producers will be the focus of debate.

Natarajan and Brickell's contribution to the issue proposes a feminist perspective that considers gendered material provisioning as a neglected category in discussions about autonomy. The wider feminist literature has drawn attention to exploitative relations within and across households, and to intense intra-household negotiations (Agarwal, 2003; Jackson, 2003) as well as inter-gender collective negotiations, in which women's organizations struggle to transform gender roles within the household (besides democratizing the decision-making process or the leadership composition in rural movements or pressuring the state for particular policies oriented at women (Deere, 2017). Natarajan and Brickell (2022) engage with feminist scholarship on women's reproductive labour, in particular through the work of Silvia Federici, and combine it with Henry Bernstein's critique that the notion of the autonomous 'peasant' represents something of an anachronism in contemporary rural life. They explore through a gendered lens how entry into markets shapes women's survival strategies. They argue that deeper market integration, for example, through women's distress sales of land and reusing of land as collateral for microfinance borrowing, simultaneously render women more dependent on markets whilst also constituting a temporary path towards an aspirational autonomy.

Jansen, Nicol, and Nikol follow with a discussion of Jan Douwe van der Ploeg's characterization of a peasantry, which centralizes peasant's struggle for autonomy in a hostile context via a self-controlled resource base. Their contribution focuses on his book *The New Peasantries* because of the enthusiastic reception of its theoretical arguments by food sovereignty scholars and agrarian movements. Van der Ploeg presents the struggle for autonomy as central to the peasant condition. After a careful dissecting of van der Ploeg's arguments they identify several areas for critique: a methodological one related to a peasant bias, an analytical one whether autonomy is a useful notion in a human society saturated with social relationships, a denial, or at best a neglect, of the complexities of agrarian class formation and differentiation, and the effect of the peasant versus Empire opposition that overlooks endogenous forms of exploitation and accumulation from below.

The contributions of Natarajan and Brickell, and Jansen et al. show the importance of taking a step back to reflect on what arguments about and calls for autonomy mean for petty commodity producers and rural labourers, recognizing differentiation as a process that better reflects the role of capital in poor rural communities than the notion of peasant. They tell us to examine the prospects and politics of peasant farming and petty commodity production in all their complexity and as much as possible free from pre-conceived assumptions. The 'peasantry' is not by essence non-capitalist or anti-capitalist, even when reproduction can encompass apparently non-capitalist socio-cultural practices. Labouring classes, even most in remote areas, do not live in isolation from other classes and capitalist relations. Consequently, the orientation of particular experiences of peasants, petty commodity producers,

and so on will depend on the contradictory political struggles that agrarian movements of a particular region are involved in, a topic we will turn to below.

4.2 | Autonomy via the market and from the market

The second discussion of autonomy has to do with the different ways of conceptualizing markets, especially the relationship between capitalist relations and non-capitalist relations. This discussion has recently focussed on the notion of autonomy (e.g. Henderson, 2019). Sankey and van der Ploeg and Schneider discuss in their contributions the relationship between autonomy and market from different perspectives. Combining a Political Marxist approach to peasant autonomy with insights from Bernstein's approach to petty commodity production, Sankey (2022) shows how different histories, levels and types of market integration within Colombia lead to different exposure to the imperative of the market and responses to the crisis of small-scale agriculture triggered by neoliberalism. Criticizing the idea of one single peasantry, she shows two different strategies. On the one hand, the coffee producers from Líbano in the Cordillera Central sought more and better market integration. On the other hand, the peasants settled in the frontier region Cimitarra Valley in the Middle Magdalena, submitted to the paramilitary violence of predatory agrarian elites, attempted to retreat from the market into subsistence agriculture and gain control of the territory by constituting themselves into 'Zona de Reservas Campesinas'. Rejecting the easy association between the peasantry and resistance, her findings point to withdrawal from the market in response to crisis, which seems to suggest a search for 'peasant' autonomy, namely a sort of autonomy from the market that could strengthen movements' political independence. But she also discusses an alternative interpretation, which perceives it as a reinforcement of neoliberal restructuring that promotes resilience of smallholder agriculture to survive crisis.

A second paper in this issue that discusses autonomy and market is from van der Ploeg and Schneider. It goes beyond van der Ploeg's peasant autonomy framework in his earlier work as discussed by Jansen, Vicol, and Nikol and develops the notion of 'nested markets'. Van der Ploeg and Schneider develop their notion of autonomy from a discussion of various ramifications of the Marxist tradition, linking up in particular with Negri. Van der Ploeg and Schneider present autonomy as something aspirational, something they observe in wider social struggles. In this contribution they identify autonomy in a set of practices that demarcate spaces within the economy as a whole. Drawing on Polanyi's conceptualization of the market as being embedded in society, they discuss the case of *O Circuito*, an extended market in Brazil constructed by a peasant movement and its urban allies. Using this case, they argue that struggles for autonomy range from farm level to the territorial level.

4.3 | Social movements, autonomy in state and non-state politics

All the contributions above already introduced questions of class, state and politics, but these questions are the central focus of the contributions by Bretón et al., Guimarães and Wanderley, and Jongerden. These three contributions raise the question of the power that peasant, indigenous or ethnic movements can mobilize on their own, and how their demands and proposals can coincide with those of other subaltern groups of society.

Bringing together discussions on peasant autonomy and indigenous autonomy that have developed in parallel more than in dialogue, Bretón et al. draw from four emblematic cases of peasant and indigenous autonomy in Latin America (the MST in Brazil, the indigenous movement in Ecuador, the indigenous and Afro-descendants in the East Coast of Nicaragua, and the peasant movement in Mexico) to critically analyse the promises, achievements, and contradictions of projects of autonomy during the era of neoliberalism. The authors assess these struggles for autonomy in regard to four of its dimensions: political independence, economic relations, ethnic/nationalist goals, and the internal politics. A focal point of the exploration of these experiences of autonomy is the difficult balancing act that peasant and indigenous movements must strike between their inter-connected agendas for autonomy. Here

the authors highlight the enormous difficulty of building and maintaining an alliance between 'strictly peasant movements' and 'strictly indigenous movements'. Another focal point is the difficulty of maintaining the levels of grassroots participation and politicization, as well as responsiveness of the leadership towards the membership, that were key in periods of opposition when movements or their allies took control of levels of governments. The paper finds that the common trajectory points to important achievements on the political front. These however opened new opportunities for wealth accumulation for some sectors, notably leaders, but did not always translate into a generalized improvement in the livelihoods of the most marginalized sectors. Peasant and indigenous autonomy should thus not be understood as an inherent quality of certain rural subjects, but as fundamentally political and cultural projects, which are negotiated as much with external forces as between internal ones.

Following a fundamentally political understanding of autonomy inspired by Cornelius Castoriadis (1987), Guimarães and Wanderley survey the different forms of organization and struggles that indigenous peasants adopted in Bolivia. By taking an historical perspective and contrasting strictly economic or sectoral organizations demanding specific policies and ethnic confederations negotiating the devolution of state jurisdictions, they present the achievements, tensions, and contradictions of the process of construction of autonomy. Drawing inspiration from Polanyi, their analysis shows that peasant syndicalist movements have managed to negotiate their relationships with the market. They did so by seeking to transform market institutions through the political recognition of their cultural distinctiveness, which translates into different practices of land ownership, labour relations, price setting, and distribution of earnings. As for indigenous movements, they find that access to part of the state, the national or local government, or the exercise of power in indigenous territories, while challenging the bourgeois state monopoly of power by creating 'nested sovereignties', did not translate into the significant transformation of the agrarian political economy of indigenous communities or more control over natural resources and territory. But even though the MAS government continued to support extractivism, the exercise of political power by indigenous peoples in different levels of the state did however significantly change the place and perception of indigenous people within Bolivian society more broadly. It also created substantial tensions within and between peasant and indigenous organizations.

The contribution of Joost Jongerden (2022) traces the influence of Murray Bookchin's autonomist thought on Kurdish intellectuals and how this made a difference in the practices of reorganizing agricultural production and food distribution, as well as political decision making. He discusses the recent Kurdish agrarian policies in Rojava to rebuild the war-ridden agrarian economy on the principle of autonomy. New local administered communities reversed old politics of state-led modernization, which had led to a squeeze on smallholder agriculture and land dispossession, and an imposition of an Arab cultural identity. Inspired by Bookchin's notion of 'democratic autonomy', measures have been taken to support family farms, the formation of cooperatives, and new local food processing facilities. Bookchin's idea of 'democratic confederalism' can be recognized in the emergence of interrelated networks of local communities that have enabled the organization of processing, distribution, and markets. Jongerden reworks ideas from Tronti and Cleaver by considering autonomy as a form of self-constitution, a struggle that is not defined by an opposition to capital and state, but rather by the desire to construct an alternative future in the here and now. For Jongerden, considering autonomy as self-constitution, as a mode of ordering, involves a rejection of the idea of autonomy as relative, which would still put capital and state central. He argues that the case of agricultural development by the Kurdish movement in Rojava and North and East Syria is better seen as a third, self-constituting, or autonomous mode of ordering.

4.4 | Autonomy and technological revolutions

The contributions by van der Ploeg and Schneider, Jansen et al., and Jongerden already mentioned how modernization trajectories, choice of technologies, and support of or hindrance to particular forms of production relate to autonomy. This topic is taken up more profoundly by Glenn Stone who explores the possible impact of big data and surveillance agriculture on farmers' autonomy. Building on a critical review of the agenda of the green revolution,

Stone shows how the emerging surveillance farming seems to be replicating earlier phases of agricultural development. Beginning from the observation that farmer's knowledge builds on a combination of 'modern' and 'agroecological' techniques, which requires farmer experimentation, he raises concerns about how the big data revolution in agriculture could lead to agricultural deskilling. This timely contribution is a looking-ahead exploration of surveillance agriculture to stimulate debate in agrarian studies on the use of information from individualized surveillance to appropriate farmer decision-making processes, digital technologies, reorganizing agribusinesses, and new capital in agriculture.

Taken together the contributions in this special issue discuss many different paths vis-à-vis the use and reproduction of resources, the market, and the state adopted by agrarian movements. They show that alternatives will not simply be determined by the 'economic class positions' of the producers involved (peasants, semi-proletarians and petty commodity producers), but also by their attempt to politically become a class and transcend these, find basis for unity, and reach out to other sectors in local, regional, national, and translational settings. The fundamental question here is how to conceptualize class, within this continuum of a basically economic category or the outcome of a political process. But beyond class, this discussion also asks what makes certain social subjects, be it peasants, indigenous peoples or revolutionaries develop an ideology and political projects that present autonomy (from the market, the state or development) as a desired horizon.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

We thank the Department of Social Sciences at Wageningen University for funding a workshop and the Rural Sociology Group for administrative support to bring the authors of this special issue together in December 2019. We are very grateful to Mindi Schneider, Max Aji, and Hashim Rashid for their critical comments on previous versions of this article, and to the anonymous reviewers of this journal for their constructive comments on the manuscript.

DATA AVAILABILITY STATEMENT

Data sharing not applicable.

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How to cite this article: Vergara-Camus, L., & Jansen, K. (2022). Autonomy in agrarian studies, politics, and movements: An inter-paradigm debate. *Journal of Agrarian Change*, 22(3), 455–472. <https://doi.org/10.1111/joac.12500>